

Over the past ten years, I have been deeply involved in several significant aspects of improving access to facilities, enhancing quality of education and promoting equity in the grading process. I will give three examples of these:

1. **introduced multiple choice question (MCQ) format for quiz tests** conducted twice every semester in our introductory physics course. India is a multi-cultural, multi-lingual country, however, the primary language used in higher education is English. Very few incoming students have sufficient proficiency in English. The introduction of MCQ format was intended to ease the challenges faced by such students and also to reduce disparity in grading arising from conscious or unconscious biases on the part of instructors.
2. **designed and implemented a new syllabus for our introductory physics course.** When I joined NITK our introductory physics syllabus (taught to all incoming freshmen) was very lengthy. Many disparate topics - relativity, quantum mechanics, semiconductors and dielectrics - were thrown in together in what appeared to be an incoherent mixture. This was because the syllabus was designed in response to demands from different engineering departments rather than as a self-consistent course intended to provide undergraduates with a solid understanding of basic physics concepts. I argued for a rationalised syllabus and designed an implemented a new course plan which included basic physics concepts: mechanics, electromagnetism and thermodynamics. All of my suggestions were not implemented but nevertheless the revised syllabus, I believe, is much more streamlined and of more suitable length than earlier.
3. **secured continuing access to a library/reading room facility for the masters students** in our department. When I joined the practice was to keep our department library and reading room under lock and key rather than to leave it open for students to use at any time. It took a lot of persuasion to convince my colleagues that these facilities exist for the benefit of our students and our job is to provide as much access as possible rather than as little. Now the reading room is kept open, at least during working hours, and students no longer have to go and ask for a key every time they want to use the room.

I was motivated to take on these challenges because I believe in the core of my being in the fundamental tenet that “all are created equal”. Therefore in whatever capacity possible, I feel it is my duty to ensure that the disadvantaged get better opportunities and that barriers to achievement are broken down rather than being built up.